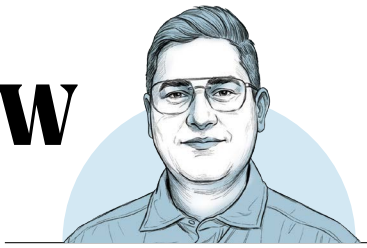
WHY INDIA NEEDS A CONSENT CHARTER NOW

The India Today-Reckitt survey reveals why building a culture of respect requires a shared national framework for consent, dignity and mutual understanding



BY PROF. RAVI BHATNAGAR

What does it take to build a society where every individual feels confident that their choices and personal boundaries will be respected?

That question inspired the INDIA TODAY and Reckitt Consent Culture Survey, which engaged 6,379 women across every state in India, in 11 languages, between May 5 and May 20 this year. The objective was not to assess legal awareness alone, but to better understand how women experience consent in their everyday lives. The findings offer valuable insights into how India can continue strengthening a culture of respect, dignity and mutual understanding.

The survey shows that while awareness of consent is growing, there is an opportunity to build greater clarity around what consent truly means in everyday interactions. Nearly six in 10 women felt that agreeing to something under pressure to avoid conflict could still be considered consent, while only about one in three clearly recognised that agreement obtained through pressure is not genuine consent. Fewer than half felt it was acceptable to change their mind after initially saying 'yes', and more than four in 10 women said they often felt the need to explain or justify a refusal.

One of the strongest insights from the survey was the influence that family and workplace environments have on how women express personal boundaries. More than four in 10 women who remained silent despite feeling uncomfortable attributed this to conditioning within these environments. This highlights the important role that homes, schools, workplaces and communities can play in encouraging open communication and creating spaces where individual choices are respected.

These findings suggest that strengthening a culture of consent is not only about legal awareness. It is equally about nurturing everyday behaviours rooted in respect, empathy and mutual understanding.

Over the years, Reckitt has sought to contribute to this journey through initiatives such as Durex The Birds and Bees Talk, a life-skills programme that has reached more than four million young people across



10 states. The programme focuses on encouraging informed conversations at an early age and creating safe spaces where young people can discuss respect, boundaries and healthy relationships with confidence.

The same philosophy has guided our engagement beyond classrooms and into cultural spaces. At Nagaland's Hornbill Festival, one of India's most celebrated cultural gatherings, we introduced Asia's first Consent Café, an immersive experience centred on consent, awareness, protection, inclusion and equity. At the Shillong Cherry Blossom Festival, thousands of young people participated in conversations through art, health education and creative expression, demonstrating that these discussions can be both meaningful and accessible.

The survey also reflects encouraging signs of readiness for wider engagement. In the Northeast and Union Territories, fewer than half of respondents said they felt comfortable directly saying 'no', and only about one in three clearly recognised that